INC-2026-02-26: Sends transactional email and SMS to cardholders and merchan degradation

Northwind Payments · SEV3 · service notify-service · author t.lindqvist

Started 2026-02-26T09:00:00Z · detected 2026-02-26T09:07:00Z · resolved 2026-02-26T09:30:00Z

Customer impact

Roughly 6,200 notification emails were sent with malformed subject lines. No payment flow was affected.

Root cause

A templating change escaped HTML entities twice, so merchant emails rendered with visible entity codes.

Causing change

This incident was caused by release notify-5.0.1, deployed to notify-service. The release is recorded in the change log.

Affected services

notify-service, checkout-api. Downstream services were affected through their dependency on notify-service.

Timeline (UTC)

09:00 — Release notify-5.0.1 completed rollout earlier in the day.

09:00 — First symptoms observed on notify-service.

09:07 — Alert pages the on-call engineer for notify-service.

09:21 — Cause identified and mitigation begins.

09:30 — Service returns to baseline; incident resolved.

Action items

• Add a pre-deploy validation check for notify-service.

• Review the third-party contract for change notification.

• Add saturation alerting to notify-service at 80% of limits.